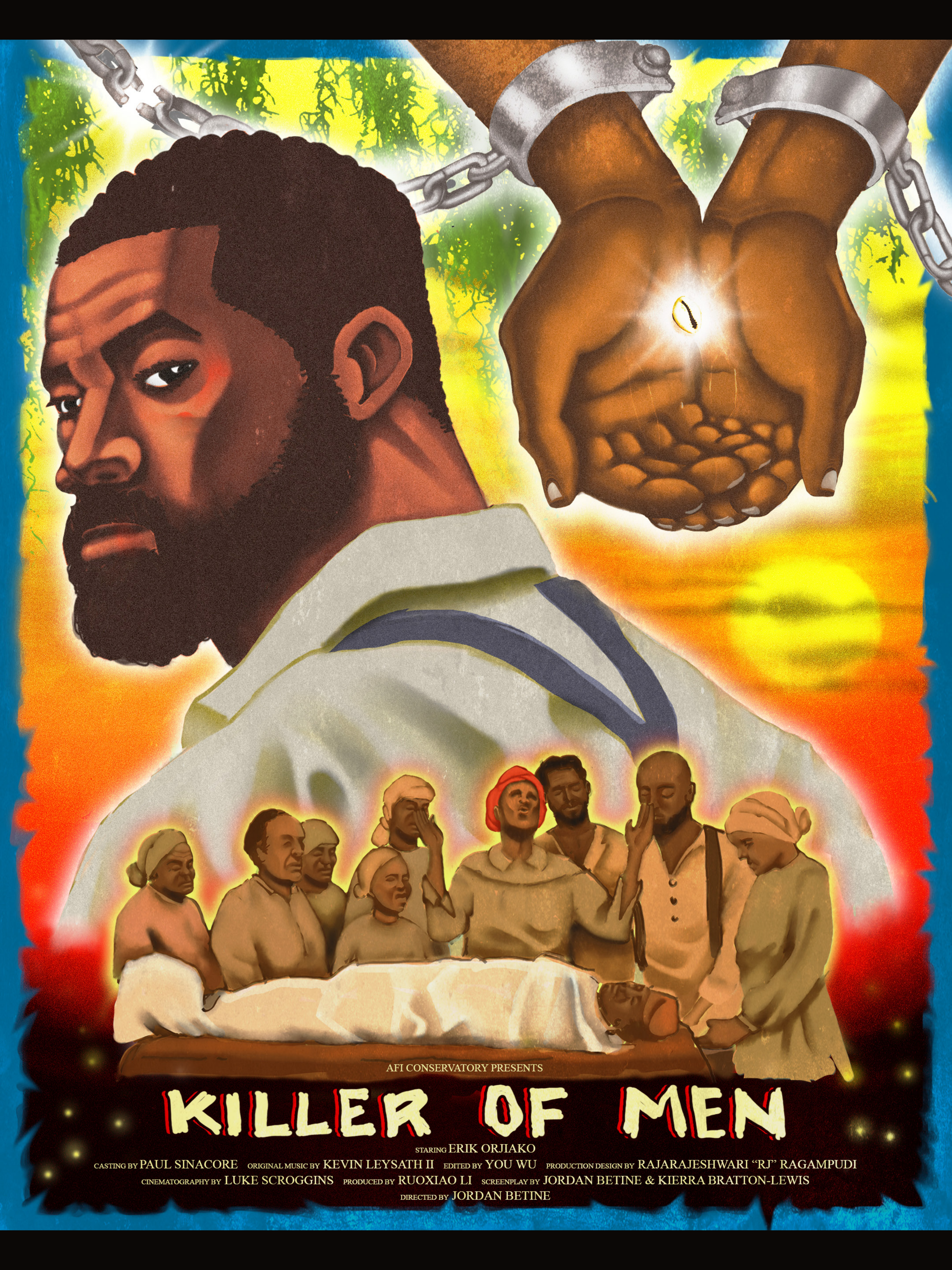




AFI CONSERVATORY PRESENTS

KILLER OF MEN

STARRING ERIK ORJAKO

CASTING BY PAUL SINACORE ORIGINAL MUSIC BY KEVIN LEYSATH II EDITED BY YOU WU PRODUCTION DESIGN BY RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI

CINEMATOGRAPHY BY LUKE SCROGGINS PRODUCED BY RUOXIAO LI SCREENPLAY BY JORDAN BETINE & KIERRA BRATTON-LEWIS

DIRECTED BY JORDAN BETINE



LOGLINE

In 1834 South Carolina, an enslaved prizefighter survives by killing his own. Every victory buys him another night and costs a man his life. He walks in on that man's burial, held in the faith of their shared ancestors, and is forced to reckon with the man he was meant to become.

SYNOPSIS

Mace fights because the alternative is the field, and then the ground. On a South Carolina plantation in 1834 his owner stages bouts against other enslaved men and takes the wagers; Mace has never lost, and every win buys him another season.

Then a fight ends in a death, and he follows the body to a burial held in secret in the Yoruba faith he was born to. The rites are for a man he killed. An elder tells him what he would have been across the water, and he sees, for the first time, what he has become.

K I L L E R O F M E N

GENRE: HISTORICAL DRAMA, SOUTHERN GOTHIC

COUNTRY: UNITED STATES

SHOOTING LOCATION: CALIFORNIA

PRODUCTION YEAR: 2025

COMPLETION YEAR: 2026

LANGUAGE: ENGLISH (.SRT AVAILABLE: ENGLISH)

DURATION: 13 MINUTES

ASPECT RATIO: 2.39:1

FRAME RATE: 24 FPS

SHOOTING FORMAT: ALEXA 35 ARRIRAW

SOUND: 5.1, STEREO

THE TEAM

WRITTEN & DIRECTED BY: JORDAN BETINE

PRODUCER: RUOXIAO LI

CINEMATOGRAPHER: LUKE SCROGGINS

PRODUCTION DESIGNER: RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI

EDITOR: YOU WU

CAST

MACE | ERIK ORJIAKO

MASTER KENNER | ERIC PARGAC

KOJO | JAMAL DENNIS

KOJO'S MASTER | CASEY LONG

FRED | CHAUNDRE HALL-BROOMFIELD

ELDER | SANDRA MCDANIELS

GIRL | LOREN FENTON

SPECTATOR | DANIEL KASSAR

SPECTATOR | NIKITA KORSHUNOV

RIGHTS

RIGHTS HOLDER: AFI CONSERVATORY

CONTACT: SUSAN DRETZKA

EMAIL: SDRETZKA@AFI.COM

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DIRECTOR'S STATEMENT

Growing up, I was always one of the youngest in my year, but my height made me one of the tallest in the class. I was often one of the biggest in the room. As I got older, I started noticing how my mere presence was often seen as either a point of praise or persecution. My physicality, tied so closely to my skin, made me seem more menacing, more dangerous than the other boys—even those bigger and stronger than I was. It's never anything overt, but small, incessant microaggressions. Death by a 1000 needles. It's a plight that's shaped me throughout my life, leaving me hyper-aware of myself in spaces. This experience, this reality, is tied to the plight of the Black man in America.

The concept of Mandingo fighting has always fascinated me. It's a strange, bastardized idea in media and literature. To me, it represents many things: the commercialization of sports and entertainment, the myth of Black-on-Black crime, the portrayal of savagery in history, and the media. It's always been used to showcase the "Black brute," but it has never been shown subjectively from the perspective of those involved. What are their lives like? What do they hold dear? What keeps a man going when he's put in a situation like that? Setting this film in slavery times, rather than in the present day or during the 1960s, allows me to examine the deep-rooted history of this aggression. Visually, I want the fight scenes to reflect the physical sports Black men often participate in—body slams, boxing, football tackles—to show history repeating itself through various forms of expression. By setting the story in the 1800s, I also had the chance to explore my heritage. With slavery still in full force and new enslaved people being brought in from Africa, I can examine the past in different ways. I want to delve into the spirituality of the enslaved at the time, capturing the mix of cultures, beliefs, and religions that slowly formed what we now know as Black culture.

Killer of Men is an expression of pain—absolute brutality and suffering. But it's also a story of resilience, culture, and spirituality. This story has kept me awake at night, terrified of what I'm putting on the screen. Killer of Men has been a grueling process—one that's forced me to question a lot of myself as a man and as a storyteller. This is my Oriki, my folktale, my poem. I won't shy away from telling difficult stories or giving a voice to the voiceless. I will honor my ancestors and my culture in everything I do.

JORDAN BETINE, WRITER-DIRECTOR

F I L M M A K E R S

WRITER-DIRECTOR | JORDAN BETINE @jordanbetine IMDB

Jordan Betine is a Nigerian-American filmmaker raised between Lagos, Nigeria, and Ashburn, Virginia. He earned his undergraduate degree in film from Howard University. Jordan studied Directing at the American Film Institute, where he directed six short films across genres, including historical drama, social realism, and surrealist comedy. His thesis film, "Killer of Men," is a historical drama set in 1830s South Carolina about an enslaved man who is forced into underground prizefighting. His work explores power, identity, and the African diaspora.

@smile_xiao624 IMDB PRODUCER | RUOXIAO LI

Ruoxiao Li is a storyteller from China. A graduate of the School of the Art Institute of Chicago, she is currently pursuing a degree in Producing at the American Film Institute. She is mentored by Lianne Halfon, whose notable works include Juno and Ghost World.



CINEMATOGRAPHER | LUKE SCROGGINS @Luscroggs IMDB



Luke Scroggins studied theater under David Connelly at the North East School of the Arts in his home town of San Antonio and continued at Otterbein University School of Theatre, earning a BFA in Acting. Television credits include SWITCHED AT BIRTH, GENERAL HOSPITAL and DAYS OF OUR LIVES. After a period coordinating and editing for fashion clients, Scroggins joined the Dark Side and began working in camera. Recently he has moved into the narrative space as Utility on the independent feature FRESH KILLS and the limited series RZR. He made his cinematographer debut on the short films COSMIC BEACH and L'DIRECTOR

PRODUCTION DESIGNER | RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI [@itsrjactually](#) [IMDB](#)



Rajarajeshwari "RJ" Ragampudi, is a recent graduate with a bachelor's degree in Architecture from India. She is recognized in her university for her undergraduate thesis, an in-depth research-based design project through the study of the films of the Indian film director, Satyajit Ray. Her experience as an Architect has helped her gain practical knowledge in spatial design, construction and project management. Along with this, she is also skilled in creative visualization with a stark interest in Film, enabling her to pursue an MFA degree in Production Design. She strives to design sets that are not only authentic to the setting but deeply character-driven, enhancing and punctuating key moments in the story.

[@ywu.0125](#) [IMDB](#) **EDITOR | YOU WU**

You Wu is a working editor with four years of professional experience. He has worked on a range of short films across different genres, contributing as both an editor and in key roles such as DIT and sound designer. Several of the films he edited have been selected for major film festivals, including LA Shorts and the Avignon International Film Festival.





MACE | ERIK ORJIAKO

Mace | Erik Orjiako Erik Orjiako is a Swedish-born Nigerian American actor and writer based in Los Angeles. He studied English and communications at UMass Amherst and earned an MFA in screenwriting at the New York Film Academy. A graduate of Second City Hollywood's improv program, he has performed with its sketch team and written shows there. His credits include the series Minx, the short film Al Davis: Just Win Baby and the podcast series The Imperfection. He has also worked as a script reader and creative executive. In Killer of Men he plays Mace. Prior credits: Minx, Al Davis: Just Win Baby, The Imperfection

Master Kenner | Eric Pargac Eric Pargac is a Los Angeles-based actor and filmmaker who grew up in Texas. He was a founding artistic director of Furious Theatre Company in Los Angeles, where he performed in ten productions and shared StageSceneLA's 2006-2007 Lead Actor of the Year (Drama) award for An Impending Rupture of the Belly. He has also performed at Artists Repertory Theatre in Portland, Intiman Theatre in Seattle and the IRT Theater in New York. His television credits include The Late Show with Stephen Colbert and HBO's Succession. He starred in, co-directed and co-produced the web series The Digressions. He is a member of SAG-AFTRA and Actors' Equity. In Killer of Men he plays Master Kenner. Prior credits: Succession, The Digressions

Kojo | Jamal Dennis Jamal Dennis is a Los Angeles-based actor and stunt performer. His training includes technique and scene study at the Royal Academy of Dramatic Art and scene study with Lesly Kahn and Craig Archibald. He holds a black belt in martial arts and has trained in Kyokushin, Wushu, Ninjutsu and Shotokan. He played the lead, Lavelle Sanders, in the series Be Someone. His screen credits include The Young and the Restless, S.W.A.T., Marvel's Runaways, Zoo, Mississippi Grind and Glory Road, and he has performed stunts on Sinners, Emancipation and Grudge Match. He is a member of SAG-AFTRA. In Killer of Men he plays Kojo. Prior credits: Mississippi Grind, S.W.A.T., The Young and the Restless, Sinners (stunts)

Elder | Sandra McDaniels Sandra McDaniels is a Los Angeles-based actress and a member of SAG-AFTRA. Her screen credits include the Apple TV+ series Truth Be Told, the short films Providence and 172 Push-Ups, and the film Gingersnap Christmas, in which she plays Gramma Belle. In Killer of Men she plays the Elder. Prior credits: Truth Be Told, Gingersnap Christmas, Providence

DRAFTS, NOT YET APPROVED. Written Sep 10 from IMDb, Backstage and the actors' own sites, then fact-checked claim by claim by eight independent checkers. Each actor should approve their bio before print. Order follows the crawl, as in 3.15. SANDRA McDANIELS HAS NO BIO OF HER OWN ANYWHERE ONLINE. Hers is built from her credits only. Ask her, or NTA Talent Agency, for her own. TO CONFIRM WITH THE ACTORS: Erik's MFA, birthplace and creative-executive work each rest on one profile he wrote himself. Eric's union membership comes from 2018 to 2020 material, Jamal's from his own resume. IMDb credits Jamal's role as "Fighter2 Kojo"; the end credits say Kojo. Sources, credit tables and the fact-check: <https://github.com/Scroggdawg/kom-festival-board/blob/main/press/cast-bios.md>



CREDITS

WRITER-DIRECTOR
JORDAN BETINE

SCREENPLAY
JORDAN BETINE
& KIERRA BRATTON-LEWIS

PRODUCER
RUOXIAO LI

CINEMATOGRAPHER
LUKE SCROGGINS

PRODUCTION DESIGNER
RAJARAJESHWARI "RJ" RAGAMPUDI

EDITOR
YOU WU

ORIGINAL MUSIC
KEVIN LEYSATH II

CASTING
PAUL SINACORE

EXECUTIVE PRODUCERS
YINGLI XIN
ZEJU ZHANG
OLAOLUWA OLUWASEUN OGUNSEYE
KAY ANN SCROGGINS

CAST

MACE	ERIK ORJIAKO
MASTER KENNER	ERIC PARGAC
KOJO	JAMAL DENNIS
KOJO'S MASTER	CASEY LONG
FRED	CHAUNDRE HALL-BROOMFIELD
ELDER	SANDRA MCDANIELS
GIRL	LOREN FENTON
SPECTATOR	DANIEL KASSAR
SPECTATOR	NIKITA KORSHUNOV

CREW

UNIT PRODUCTION MANAGER	SHIRLEY SUI	SET DRESSERS	NICOLE KUANG
FIRST ASSISTANT DIRECTOR	EDDY GUDAKOV		SHIRLEY WU
SECOND ASSISTANT DIRECTOR	KEVIN PRESCOTT		JAHNVI GUPTA
COLORIST	WALTER VOLPATTO		NAOMI STEVENS
STUNT COORDINATOR	ZEDRIC HARRIS		CHANEL KALINSKI
STILL PHOTOGRAPHER	JEDIDIAH WOODS		CORAL LOMELI
SOUND DESIGNER	STILL UNKNOWN	ART PAS	ADRIAN GONZALEZ
			ROMAN RAYNES
CAMERA OPERATOR	DOMINIKA PODCZASKA		CHERICE CARR
STEADICAM	DAE HYUN KIM		CHEN JING
FIRST ASSISTANT CAMERA	JULIA MAIXER		JUE "JADE" LIN
SECOND ASSISTANT CAMERA	TRISTIAN IBARRA MARTIN	SCENIC PAINTER	ANDREW LEE
DIT	KATE KEYING WU		MAYRA C. SAUCEDO
STILL PHOTOGRAPHER	JEDIDIAH WOODS	COSTUME DESIGNER	X. HILL
SECOND UNIT CAMERA	REB RICHARD	ASSISTANT COSTUME	ODESSA NEWMAN
	ELIOT GRIGO	DESIGNERS	JOLISA OSBORN-POLAKOFF
		DEPARTMENT HEAD	SHAWNEE CERKOWNIAK
LINE PRODUCER	COLT KOZAL	MAKEUP AND SFX MAKEUP	
SCRIPT SUPERVISORS	LIBBY MCNEIL	KEY MAKEUP ARTIST	NEVE ANDREWS
	ZHIYAN LIU		
PRODUCTION COORDINATOR	JACK RUEFLI	ASSISTANT EDITOR	HAZEL YUNTONG DAI
2ND SECOND	JAPHET E. VELAZQUEZ	COLORIST	WALTER VOLPATTO
ASSISTANT DIRECTOR			
		PYROTECHNIC DESIGNER	JOHN EGGETT
GAFFER	ADAM BIRCH	FIRE SAFETY ADVISORS	WILLIAM MOORHEAD
BEST PERSON ELECTRIC	CHANSOUL TAO		KERRY YIM
ELECTRIC	JULES HOWARD		TIM RUDDELL
	THOMAS LIAN	SNAKE WRANGLER	AARON WELLS
	ERIC HE	ON-SET MEDIC	GREG LEVINE
KEY GRIP	WEILAND KURT	DRIVERS	ZHANYIN XIAO
BEST PERSON GRIP	EUGENE VISE		CLAUDIO DEL PINO MERCADO
DOLLY GRIP	ALEXANDER HAGEMAN		COLT KOZAL
COMPANY GRIP	JASPER KHADJENOURI	OFFICE PRODUCTION	EVELYN TANG
	HASAN IQBA	ASSISTANTS	HONGYU AN
	MATTHEW ROVETO		CLAUDIO DEL PINO MERCADO
PRODUCTION SOUND MIXER	JACOB ELIETT	PRODUCTION ASSISTANTS	TONGHAN "ANDI" TIAN
BOOM OPERATOR	DAY WREN		JUDE BRANDFORD-SACKEY
			DAMINABO PETERSIDE
ART DIRECTORS	TREY WRIGHT		TYLER FISHER
	FERNANDO ACUNA		NICHOLAS COLLINS
ASSISTANT ART DIRECTORS	JAMES ROBERT		JOSHUA MONTREL
	CYAN MIREILLE		KAYODE OLADEJI
		CATERING	BIOLA OLATERU-OLAGBEGI
			KYLIE ROTHFIELD

EXTRAS

D'SHAE J BEASLEY
MEL HAMPTON
AYODEJI FATIGUN
CHARLES KIEMA
TYLER FISHER

NIKKIA DANIELLE MATTHEWS
OLAOLUWA OLUWASEUN OGUNSEYE
PATIENCE DOOSHIMA OHABUIKE
YOULANDA DAVIS
DANNY POTTER

RICARDO VARGAS
ROB MARK SADUSKI
GAGE PHILLIPS
ERIK SCILLEY
ANTHONY AROYAN

THE FILMMAKERS WISH TO THANK

SHIQI SUKIA ZHANG
XUANNING ZHANG
DONGPO XU
QING LIAO
LINA HU
PING GUO & BAOZHEN LING
XIE LINCHEN
WEIWEI XU
KUAI YU
XIAOMIN ZHANG
XUANFANG GAO

LIN YI
MALLIK
& PREETHI RAGAMPUDI
SANTOS VELAZQUEZ
& ANADELIS FIGUEROA
DAWN AND J. MARTIN
AKSHAY KUMAR
PADMA CHITRAPU
SRIRAM CHINTALAPATI
SAIRAM TADIGADAPA
SRINI TIPIRNENI

RAGHURAM
& KANCHAN DEVARAKONDA
NELLA SUBRAMANIAM
& SHAILA NELLAI
PHILLIP BROOKS
TRACEY B
BYRON CHANG
SALAAR KHAN
YUHONG LAI & CHUNHUI WU
CECIL GAO

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RAJARAJESHWARI RAGAMPUDI	AFI PRODUCTION DESIGN FELLOW
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JORDAN UWHUBETINE	AFI DIRECTING FELLOW
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